Though we lost the first Test in Mumbai in three days, we did have our moments in the match. I scored 76 in the first innings, getting out when I went for an expansive shot to a McGrath delivery that was wide of off stump. In the Australian first innings we reduced them to 99–5, with Harbhajan Singh taking three quick wickets, before an aggressive counter-attacking partnership between Hayden and Gilchrist took the match away from us again. We dropped a few catches and they both managed to score hundreds, giving Australia a sizeable first-innings lead.

We started the second innings with thirty overs remaining in the second day and had lost two wickets by the time we came to the last over. Then the nightwatchman Nayan Mongia was hit on the finger by a ball from Gillespie and retired hurt. I had to go in and play out the last five balls, a task that is never easy, particularly with Gillespie bowling at his best. The next morning I resumed with Rahul Dravid, knowing it was going to be a stern test of our character. McGrath and Gillespie were bowling in tandem and while Rahul mostly played Gillespie, I played out a very good spell from McGrath. We hardly rotated strike, knowing that once we had played out the initial burst from these two bowlers, things would become a lot easier.

I scored a half-century but I think even my harshest critic would concede that I got out in a most unfortunate manner. I played a full-blooded pull shot to a short Mark Waugh delivery, which would have been a definite boundary had the ball not hit Justin Langer's back at forward short leg and spooned up to midwicket. Ricky Ponting ran fifteen yards and dived forward for a very good catch. The momentum had shifted and Australia soon capitalized on the advantage and closed out the game. The Australians had now won sixteen straight Tests and needed to win just one more to set a new world record.

Second Test, Kolkata, 11–15 March 2001

The Kolkata Test match was undoubtedly one of the best I played in, but it didn't start well for us. Australia scored 445 in the first innings, thanks to 110 from Steve Waugh and 97 from Matthew Hayden, and when we were at a dismal 128–8 at the end of day two, with the Australian quartet of McGrath, Gillespie, Kasprowicz and Warne all taking wickets, not even the most ardent Indian fan thought we'd be able to save the match. I had scored ten in our first innings and everybody was dejected after our